

One Choice Changes Everything

CHOOSE YOUR WORK



Redefine Success and Discover the Work
That Makes You Feel Fully Alive

DAN DOBOS

7

Let the Work Choose You

How to tap into your intuition to reach the next level of growth.

The Secret to the Success of Steve Jobs, Oprah Winfrey, and Albert Einstein

Humanity has achieved some incredible things. We've designed airplanes and rockets and traveled to the Moon. We've built soaring skyscrapers, the Eiffel Tower, the Sistine Chapel, and created GPS technology to easily navigate from one place to another. We painted the Mona Lisa, composed Boléro, and created countless other incredible works of art and music. We split the atom, spliced the genome, and sequenced our DNA. We now have more computing power in our pocket than the system that sent the first rocket to the Moon.

Were these achievements accomplished by someone who worked for ten minutes, checked social media, did another fifteen minutes, watched a YouTube video, did another seven minutes, and then got a snack? Were these things achieved by someone who was constantly procrastinating? Is that how we sent a rocket to the Moon? No. How then were these feats accomplished?

CHOOSE YOUR WORK

Let's start with the iPhone. Steve Jobs is widely known as the co-founder of Apple. What's not as well known is the journey he took just before founding Apple. When Jobs was in his early twenties, he was unsure of his purpose and direction. He dropped out of Reed College to explore different paths. Jobs then traveled to India to study Zen Buddhism. During this time, he felt a profound sense of peace and clarity as he discovered the importance of intuition.

Based on that formative experience, Jobs founded Apple with Steve Wozniak and emphasized that intuition guided the design and features of the iPod, iPhone, and iPad. While Jobs was admired for his exceptional technological achievements, he did not attribute his success to his technical skills. He attributed it to listening to his intuition. It's no coincidence that Oprah Winfrey, Albert Einstein, Steven Spielberg, and Serena Williams all placed a high value on intuition.

To what degree do you use your intuition in your work? When you're dealing with tasks you don't enjoy, it's common to start and stop because your heart just isn't in it. We have all procrastinated out of laziness, but sometimes procrastination provides a clue that maybe this is not the work you're meant to do. Work *hindered by procrastination* becomes a battle of self-discipline as you push yourself to get it done. In contrast, work *guided by intuition* is a listening activity that pulls you into its warm embrace.

Observe the moments when work pulls you in. This book is called *Choose Your Work*, but actually, you want to listen for when the work is choosing you. This is particularly important because there are many ways to hack procrastination, such as using a countdown timer to focus on a single task and putting one song on repeat. These techniques work; we overcome procrastination and get the job done. But be careful what you wish for because you might just get it. You get the job done while you neglect the work that you are meant to do. Grinding through tasks may bring you praise from others, but it does not justify abandoning your true self. We are told to develop grit to be successful, but what about the dark side of grit?

The Dark Side of Grit

Writer and venture capitalist Paul Graham tells the story about his friend, a successful doctor who constantly complained about her job. When she was in high school, she impulsively decided to be a doctor. She let her high school self choose her adult life and, driven solely by ambition, persisted despite it being a dull and draining experience. This is the sunk cost fallacy in motion.

The sunk cost fallacy is a cognitive bias that we all experience, causing us to make irrational decisions. It occurs when we let past investments dictate future choices. We continue to spend time, money, or effort on a project that no longer serves us purely because we feel committed to our initial investment. We stay in a job we hate because we are about to get promoted. We don't change careers because we have spent so long establishing our skills in our current profession. We hate admitting our mistakes, so we engage in behavior that is counterproductive. This needs to stop.

The first step to overcoming the sunk cost fallacy is to realize you cannot change the past. You only have from today until the end of your life, so embrace the remaining time. Develop thoughtful quit criteria. These are the conditions that, if met, mean it is time for you to move on. For example, you may require a quiet, peaceful environment free from abusive language, along with challenging work that makes you think deeply for long, uninterrupted periods of time. Define conditions that are meaningful to you, with as many specifics as possible, and then give yourself at least a few months to assess whether these criteria are being met. Journal each day and summarize your thoughts each week. After a few months, it will become obvious what you need to do next.

I remember being halfway through my engineering degree, knowing that I would never become an engineer, but the sunk cost fallacy kept me captive for several more years. I clung to my engineering degree, telling myself I had invested too much time and effort to abandon it, even though my heart wasn't in it. Every time I thought about switching

CHOOSE YOUR WORK

paths, I felt an overwhelming sense of embarrassment. I didn't want to admit to friends and family that I had just wasted several years of my life. It was not until I left my corporate job that I realized clinging to the past was preventing me from choosing my work in the present. Letting go of that sunk cost was liberating, allowing me to appreciate each moment of the work that I was meant to do.

As a business owner, I also couldn't help recognizing the grip that the sunk cost fallacy had on my journey. The countless hours, the intense effort, and the emotional investment meant that it was all too easy to stay tethered to my business out of sheer inertia. I gradually realized that every business owner will leave their business one day. The question is not if, but when and why. Will it be at the peak of your health and enthusiasm, strategically planned for optimal sale value? Or will it be a reluctant retirement, driven by necessity rather than desire? Confronting the sunk cost fallacy forced me to define my own exit strategy. It challenged me to honestly assess whether my business was fulfilling my deepest aspirations or merely holding me hostage to past decisions.

Ultimately, I recognized that while I greatly enjoyed operating the business, writing brought me more joy. Having fallen prey to the sunk cost fallacy in the past, I was better equipped to identify its subtle influence. So, I decided to do whatever it took to hire a replacement.

Grit and determination can be useful. These qualities helped me get good grades and a highly sought-after corporate job. But the downside of grit and determination is that they are blind. Grit got me into a job that appeared impressive but felt completely meaningless. It took me some time to realize that untempered ambition is so narrowly focused that it lacks the space to listen to intuition. It coaxes us to plow forward, to surge ahead, to power through. But if you're on the wrong path, forward motion is just applying force to a dead end.

Why Intuition Must Come Before Grit

To see why intuition must guide grit, let's examine the diagram displayed below. Intuition is the fourth quadrant; it is what you don't know that you know.

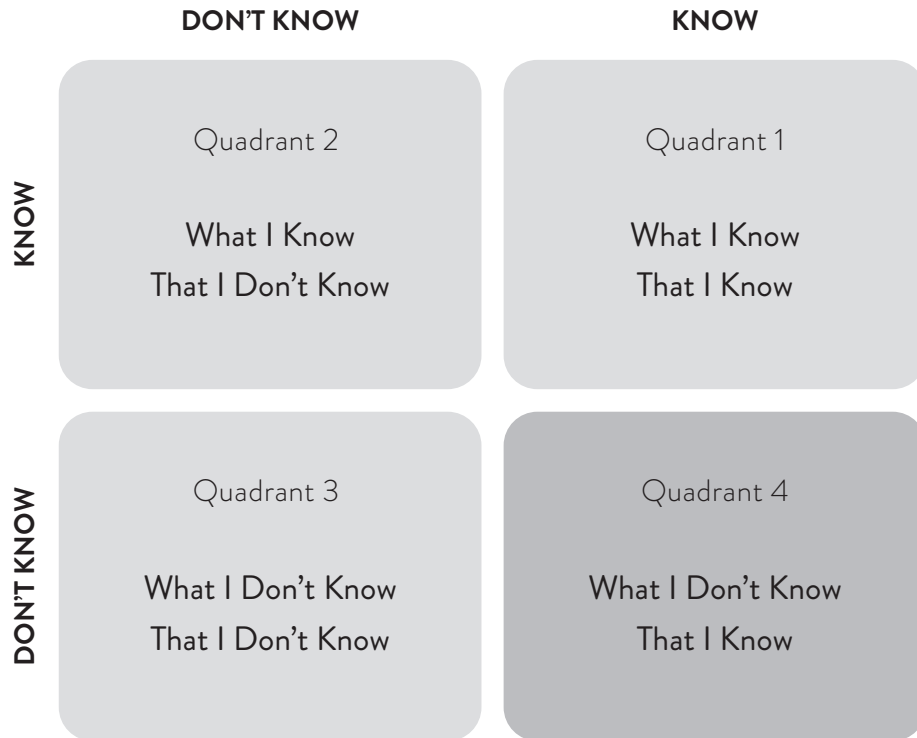


Figure 3: The Awareness Map

Quadrant One is what you know that you know. You know the capital city of the country you call home.

Quadrant Two is what you know that you don't know. You know that you don't know about astrobiology.

Quadrant Three is what you don't know that you don't know. These aren't just things you don't know. These are topics that you have no awareness of. For example, the Dunning–Kruger effect is a cognitive bias where people with low skill at a task overestimate their ability. Many are

unaware of this bias, acting with overconfidence to their detriment. The things you don't know that you don't know are your blind spots.

Quadrant Four is the most important quadrant for this book. It is what you don't know that you know. This may sound a bit odd. At first you may say, "Either I know it, or I don't know it!" But it's not that simple. Let's say that you experienced an emotional event and you decide to write about it. As you write, insights arrive that you were not able to access before you started writing. You refine your writing even further. At the end of it, you exclaim, "Huh! Interesting! I didn't realize that I knew this. I will have to put my reflections in writing more often."

Putting your reflections in writing is one way to activate your intuition because it reduces the unhelpful chatter in your head. How else can we tap into our intuition?

The Body Contains Wisdom That the Mind Cannot Comprehend

The work that you are meant to do is not an answer you get back from doing an online personality quiz. It's not an analytical process. It is not a task you can check off. The problem is that we have been schooled to be so logical that it's easy to lose touch with what feels right. Our culture does not encourage us to pause and reflect; it encourages us to get things done and move to the next project. These conditions make it nearly impossible to make any meaningful progress.

Your work is a mystery waiting to be discovered. Just as you are unique, so too is your work. To tap into the distinctiveness that you embody, you need to penetrate to the core of your true self. Start by becoming intensely aware of how you feel when you engage in your work. What sort of sensations are you experiencing in your body?

- Are you breathing slowly and steadily, or quickly and unevenly?
- Is your body feeling energized or lethargic?

- Is your heart feeling calm or is it racing?
- Is your mind clear or confused?
- Are you smiling or frowning?
- Is your stomach feeling calm or uneasy?
- Are your eyes focused or constantly wandering?
- Do you have an extra spring in your step as you approach the start of work? Or is there hesitation?

I remember a moment early in my career, sitting in a high-rise office building, staring out at the cityscape. It was a prestigious job with a respectable salary, everything I was told I should want. But as I sat there, I felt this gnawing sensation in my chest, like something was profoundly wrong. It was a feeling I couldn't shake, a sense that I was not where I was supposed to be. At the time, I didn't understand it, but looking back, I realize it was my true self desperately trying to speak to me, urging me to listen to my intuition to find a path that resonated with my heart.

It's essential to distinguish between intuition and anxiety, as they can sometimes feel similar. Anxiety often presents as repetitive, fearful thought patterns, a loud sense of impending doom, or physical reactions like racing thoughts, shallow breathing, physical tension, and even a sense of panic. It tends to be rooted in a fear of the unknown or past experiences.

In contrast, intuition is more of a calm and persistent inner knowing. It's a quieter, more grounded feeling from your true self that guides you in a particular direction. While anxiety seeks to keep you safe by avoiding perceived dangers, intuition guides you toward your true path, often despite the fear. Learning to recognize this distinction can help you trust your intuition and follow it, even when it seems challenging.

Listen to your intuition. It contains inner wisdom that transcends logic. Its message provides the ultimate clue to help you choose your work.

Where Does Intuition Begin?

Connecting with your intuition is much like dreaming. While you can't force yourself to have a peaceful dream, you can relax before you go to bed. Similarly, intuition can't be forced, but you can create the ideal conditions.

Interestingly, neuroscience research has shown that increasing your heart rate variability (HRV) can enhance your intuition by strengthening the connection between your heart and brain. Studies have shown that higher HRV is associated with clearer thinking and improved intuitive decision-making. The starting point to increasing your HRV is to exercise daily, get consistent high-quality sleep, and engage in a mindfulness practice like breathwork or meditation.

To tap into your intuition, you need to tap into the deeper part of consciousness beyond the mind. Intuition begins at the end of thought. To get to the point beyond thought, write down every thought in your head. Keep writing until you can think of nothing more.

Thoughts are loud. You want to empty your mind of its chatter. This is why it's so important to contextualize the challenges from the past (see Chapter 2) and to get in touch with your true self (see Chapter 5).

You want to amplify the soft signals of the body over any reaction. You will connect with your intuition in the silent space beyond stimulus and response.

At least once a week, go to a park, forest, or beach, immerse yourself in nature, and start walking. Put your phone and watch out of reach, walk at a leisurely pace, and take in the peaceful surroundings. This simple act shuts down the industrial mindset that has turned time into a commodity that is bought and sold. When you stop measuring time and start inhabiting it, the mind begins to settle. Your body will feel lighter, mental chatter will fade, and intuition will gradually reveal itself. Open yourself to the deepest part of your being. Open yourself to possibility.

As you contemplate *your work* — not what job you're going to get — listen for a gentle nudge about a journey that you need to embark on. Listen to the quiet voice that softly seeks to guide you. Frequently, things will surface that you have always known to be true but somehow ignored. In this serene state, fresh insights emerge, pointing toward the work that you are meant to do.

*It will begin as a faint murmur, barely noticeable, scarcely seen.
But then you notice subtle hints.
Seemingly random events will collide to steer you to your work.
The quiet hush evolves into a soft hum.
The more you listen, the clearer the signal.
It's no longer a whisper, but a feeling and a knowing.
The feeling deepens, gains momentum, and transforms into energy.
The energy flows through your body like a wave of deep meditation.
You see your true self with clarity you've never experienced before.
The clarity is so intensely bright that you are left with no option
but to do your work... because to abstain would be to willfully
desert your true self in the light of day.
And just as a mother would never abandon her child, your primal
instincts do not permit you to desert your true self.
In this state, you are fully focused.
Distractions are a thing of the past.
Your fixity of attention calmly arises from your fixity of intention.
You progress rapidly because the path feels deeply right.
Your work feels natural.
It flows.
Gone is the resistance suffered from doing the wrong work.*

As you listen to the quiet call of intuition, it becomes increasingly difficult to accept the conventional definitions of failure and success.

The Definition of Failure

We have been told that the difference between success and failure lies in achieving goals that are specific, measurable, achievable, relevant, and time-bound. Notice how this definition omits any consideration of whether your work feels intrinsically right. This paradigm is based on a finite game, a game played to win and which ends once the time frame has expired.

If you write a book specifically to sell a certain number of copies, you are playing a finite game. You plan the book, write the book, and promote the book with the hope of achieving your goal. If you sell the number of copies in the given time frame, you are successful. If you do not, you are labeled a failure. But the real failure is being so attached to a finite game that you never play an infinite game.

In contrast to a finite game, an infinite game goes on forever. The sole reason for engaging in an infinite game is the inherent value of playing the game. You engage in work simply because the work feels *right*, because you have listened to your intuition. You may, for example, dedicate your life to the art of writing, to sharing impactful messages through various media, and to continually improving your ability to express yourself. You celebrate your victories and seek to grow from your failures, but in doing so, you realize that neither your victories nor your failures can diminish the intense fulfillment you derive from your writing journey.

So what pursuit is worth doing for at least a decade simply because it captivates your imagination?

When you find work that resonates with you, don't ignore it. It may take time for the practical aspects of your work to come together. That's okay because you are playing an infinite game, not a finite one. Your ability to identify an infinite game is far more valuable than any minor victory in a finite game.

If you write a book and don't get the results you want, but you know in your heart of hearts that you were put on this planet to write books,

that's okay. The field of writing is deep. If you audition for a role in a theater production and don't get it, that's okay. There will be other roles. The journey is not over.

Do not let a finite game deceive you into defining success as achieving a specific outcome in a given amount of time. Real success is about being so engaged in an activity that time disappears. There is great peace in knowing that you are fully complete, so you do not need to play a finite game. Instead, you focus on an infinite game that is the greatest expression of your wholeness. The short term becomes less important because you are fully committed to making things work in the long term.

When you are committed to the long term, you let go of any thought about the outcome and simply focus on giving your best to each input. As you focus on the inputs, you develop a love of questions. These questions irrepressibly urge you to keep pushing toward the next level. Perhaps nothing is more fulfilling than this deep-seated bittersweet love.

Amid the chaos and the distractions, you know that there is no rush. You sit back, comforted by the awareness that while the path is steep, it is the right path, and so you have no choice but to follow the winding trail. As you focus on the infinite game, you achieve more than you can imagine. Unexpected magic awaits you at each turn. This magic is not just in the achievements, but in the joy of playing the game without worrying about the finish line. You attract others who are also playing an infinite game, and together, you positively reinforce each other's journey. Together, you build an infinite culture that leaves a lasting impact far beyond the confines of any finite game.

Let's tap into your intuition through the reflection activity.

The Intuitive Path

1. *What is one recurring practice (e.g., walking, journaling, breathwork) I will do this week to listen more deeply to my intuition? When is the best time to schedule it in my calendar?*
2. *What's one decision I'm currently facing where I could use intuition as a guide?*
3. *When I tap into the subtle signals my intuition is sending me, what is the infinite game that I am being led to play?*

Duration

Three minutes

Spend a few minutes in quiet reflection, tuning into your body's subtle signals. Then write for a few minutes about the infinite game that emerges, allowing yourself to dream big and embrace the long-term vision.

Sometimes you might need to go on several walks before the signal is clear. Revisit this monthly as you cultivate your intuition. Your inner voice becomes clearer with consistent practice and attention.

This image shows a single sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and run across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

-

-

Praise for *Choose Your Work*

Choose Your Work is both deeply personal and profoundly universal. It is insightful, provocative, and quietly unsettling. It seamlessly blends research and real-world anecdotes with practical, step-by-step guidance to help you identify what matters most. This is a book for anyone who has ever sensed there must be more — more meaning, more joy, more alignment between who they are and the work they do.

Genia Janover | Award-Winning Former Principal | Bialik College | Former Fellow | Australian College of Educators

Dan Dobos says the scary, quiet thing out loud: how we spend our working lives is a choice. *Choose Your Work* is both a wake-up call and a practical roadmap for anyone ready to make that choice.

Ben Stickland | Co-Founder & CEO | Instamove

This is the kind of book I will go back to regularly. Some self-help books you read once. Others bring value over and over throughout your life. This is the latter.

Teshia Harding

Choose Your Work distills a lifetime of insights and wisdom into a practical guide to help you clarify what matters most.

Jonar Nader | Former IBM Executive | Author of *How to Lose Friends & Infuriate Your Boss*

Chapter Two alone helped me more than therapy has.

Kayla Giles

Choose Your Work is a timely and deeply needed guide for anyone who senses there must be more to work than simply earning a living. In a volatile world that pushes people toward conformity, this book offers a practical and thought-provoking path back to what truly matters.

Mark Bowles | Dean, Tasmanian School of Business and Economics | University of Tasmania

In my work as a psychotherapist, I see how easy it is to lose sight of who you truly are. *Choose Your Work* offers a thoughtful and compelling path back to yourself.

Kirk Fisher | Psychotherapist & Zen Teacher

Honest, raw, and real. *Choose Your Work* was exactly what I needed.

Christy Oshima

Unlike other career change manuals, this is a guide for those searching for fulfilling work that is both optimistic and encouraging.

Helen Praetz | Emeritus Professor and Former Pro Vice-Chancellor | RMIT University

If you know someone graduating college, buy them this book. If a friend just turned 30, buy them this book. Most people stumble into careers that 'kinda work' and there they remain stuck. Don't be like most people. Buy this book.

James Tuckerman | Founder | Anthill Magazine

Contents

	The Key to Making This Book Work for You	xiii
	This is not a book to simply read.	
1	What If My Whole Life Has Been Wrong?	1
	Why do so many people experience a deep sense of regret at the end of their lives?	
	<i>Pause: The Three-Year Mirror</i>	
2	The Unexpected Gifts Hidden in Your Struggles	17
	How to extract insights from your greatest challenges so they become pathways for growth.	
	<i>Pause: The Hidden Gift</i>	
3	Don't Confuse Success with Suffering in Comfort	33
	Why your focus on comfort is ruining your life and obscuring the true metrics of success.	
	<i>Pause: The Comfort Trap</i>	
4	How Do You Pay the Bills and Still Choose Your Work?	49
	The one hour that changes everything.	
	<i>Pause: The Hour of Possibility</i>	
5	How to Think Independently in a World Obsessed with Conformity	63
	Why does conforming to the herd hamper your personal growth?	
	<i>Pause: The Hidden Voice</i>	
6	Rational Work Only Produces Rational Results	79
	The unexpected path to extraordinary achievement.	
	<i>Pause: The Rational Trap</i>	
7	Let the Work Choose You	91
	How to tap into your intuition to reach the next level of growth.	
	<i>Pause: The Intuitive Path</i>	
8	How to Overcome the Curse of Competence	105
	Why traditional education may undervalue your greatest strength and what to do about it.	
	<i>Pause: The Curse of Competence</i>	

9	You Don't Really Want to Lie on the Beach All Day	115
	What is more valuable than \$100 million in cold hard cash?	
	<i>Pause: The Cathedral</i>	
10	Next Steps to a Fulfilling Life	131
	How to capitalize on this pivotal moment.	
	<i>Pause: The One Project</i>	
	Appendices	
1	Action Plan	141
	A roadmap to convert your insights into action.	
2	How Well-Meaning Parents Unknowingly Steer Their Children Away from Fulfilling Work	145
	Understanding the subtle yet powerful influence parents have on career choices.	
3	What Next?	149
	Stay connected and inspired on your path to fulfilling work.	
4	Frequently Asked Questions	151
	Answers to the most common questions about choosing your work.	
5	The Ten Most Important Questions to Help You Choose Your Work	153
	Start with just one question each day.	
6	Financial Planning for Choosing Your Work	157
	Practical financial strategies to help you on your new path.	
7	Summary and Bonus Strategies	159
	A short guide to help you take action.	
	Notes	161
	Index	190

**Have you ever felt the unnerving sensation that,
despite appearing successful, something deep down isn't quite right?**

When you look back at your life, will you be satisfied?
Or will you have regrets?

The dark side of grit is chasing goals that don't matter,
while your deepest desires quietly fade away.

The way forward is to realize that the secret to a
fulfilling life is to choose your work.

**In this thought-provoking book, packed with inspiration,
practical strategies, and insightful stories, you will discover...**

What is more valuable than \$100 million in cold hard cash?

•

How to extract insights from your greatest challenges to realize your potential

•

Strategies to choose your work while still paying the bills

•

Why being good at something may lead you down the
wrong path and how to find the right one

•

Why focusing on comfort can ruin your life and
obscure the true metrics of success



**This book will help you discover your deepest truth, redefine what
success means to you, and begin a fulfilling new chapter in your journey.**

"Compelling and thought-provoking. It inspired immediate action in my life."

Beau Florenosos

"Inspirational, memorable and unlike any self-help book I've read before."

Jean Rose Dogillo

"Engaging, energising and deeply thought-provoking."

Liz Treat